Your new **.env** file will store critical settings like database credentials, mail configurations, and the application key. This separation of configuration from the codebase is essential as you begin to add more functionality and eventually move into production.

Generating Unique Application Key

A unique application key secures your encrypted data and user sessions. We can generate this key using the Laravel Artisan command:

```
php artisan key:generate
```

This command automatically updates your **.env** file with a newly generated key and confirms that the application is now secure. The key acts as a safeguard against vulnerabilities.

Verifying Laravel Setup

To ensure that everything is running smoothly, let's start the built-in Laravel development server using Artisan: